

**“Is she a wife or a mother?”
Social order, respect, and address in Mijikenda¹**

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ABSTRACT

Mijikenda social relationships are of two types, “respectful” and “joking.” In this northeastern Bantu language of Kenya, respect based on kinship requires an overt linguistic marker: adjacent generations (parents and children) “respect” one another and address each other using plural forms. Kin of the same generation (siblings, cousins) and of alternate generations (grandparents, grandchildren) “joke” with one another and address each other in the singular. Accordingly, address form in Mijikenda signals and reaffirms generational identity and relative position in a well-defined social structure. It is also normatively associated with “correct” behavior. As pronouns of respect occur in such small-scale, nonstratified Bantu societies (and throughout the world), it is suggested that Brown and Gilman’s (1960) particular hypothesis for the origin and spread of T/V respect systems needs to be replaced by a more socially persuasive and general explanation for a widespread phenomenon. (Sociolinguistics, pronouns of address, T/V systems, kinship, Kenya languages, Bantu)

Two cardinal premises of contemporary sociolinguistics are that (1) language normally and naturally covaries with speech situations; and that (2) speakers and addressees exchange a multiplicity of social and interpersonal information, over and above the referential or propositional content of their exchanges. Speakers’ language competence naturally requires and reflects the use of extralinguistic knowledge, as well as rules of appropriateness, so that they can frame a message that is not merely meaningful, grammatical, and stylistically appropriate, but is well formulated in terms of the social structures and social categories that regulate a given speech community. In Mijikenda societies, this essential congruency between linguistic and social knowledge is demonstrated in a particularly striking way in interpersonal address, by the joint use of pronominal address forms and associated lexical kinship terms, which covary to reflect the underlying social organization.²

PRONOUNS OF RESPECT AND INTIMACY

Research in the field of address, as well as the norms and variations that occur cross-culturally, was given a major stimulus in the influential article by Brown and Gilman (1960) on pronouns of power and solidarity. The focus of this article was on Indo-European languages, mainly western European (excluding contemporary standard English). In the article, Brown and Gilman put forward a hypothesis for the origin and spread (within a particular social and historical framework) of differentiated 2nd person address forms in European languages and for the stimulus diffusion of their semantic system into adjacent language areas.

The study of sociolinguistic rules of address has grown greatly since the late 1950s, and material is now available on a far wider range of languages than those examined by Brown and Gilman. Pioneering studies of individual languages such as Maranao (McKaughan 1959), Javanese (Geertz 1960), Japanese (Martin 1964), Dyirbal (Dixon 1972), and Amharic (Hoben 1976) have been complemented by an extensive comparative literature concerning politeness universals (Brown & Levinson 1987), address systems (Braun 1988; Braun, Kohz, & Schubert 1986; Philipsen & Huspek 1985), and pronoun systems (Mühlhäusler & Harré 1990). A considerable amount of data is now available enabling us to extend and refine parts of the Brown and Gilman hypothesis. It is to this literature that the present article, dealing with material from a Bantu subgroup, aims to make a contribution.

THE MIJIKENDA

The Mijikenda, numbering ca. 700,000 in the 1979 census, form the largest ethnic group in Kenya's Coast Province. Their name is Swahili in origin and means 'nine communities or groups' (but see Spear 1978:46). It replaces the indigenous term *Midzichenda* and earlier *Makayachenda*. An even earlier term, *Wanyika*, is no longer used.

The largest and best-known subgroup is the Giriama (numbering about 300,000); next largest demographically are the Duruma and Digo (about 150,000 each), followed by the Chonyi and Rabai (about 35,000 each). Finally the four smallest groups, with approximately 10,000 members each, are the Kambe, Kauma, Jibana, and Ribe. The Mijikenda dialect continuum consists of varieties that are closely related and for the most part mutually intelligible, with percentages of cognate core lexis ranging from 78 percent to 94 percent (Van Otterloo & Van Otterloo 1980:7). Mutual intelligibility between the dialects is strengthened by an awareness of identity conveyed in traditions of origin and migration common to all the subgroups. All of them use the address systems described.

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TABLE 1. *Subject pronouns*

Person	Giriama	Chonyi	Swahili
Singular			
1 I'm working	<i>ninahenda kazi</i>	<i>(ni)nahenda kazi</i>	<i>ninafanya kazi</i>
2 you...	<i>unahenda...</i>	<i>unahenda...</i>	<i>unafanya...</i>
3 he/she...	<i>anahenda...</i>	<i>yunahenda...</i>	<i>anafanya...</i>
Plural			
1 we...	<i>ϕunahenda...</i>	<i>hunahenda...</i>	<i>tunafanya...</i>
2 you...	<i>munahenda...</i>	<i>munahenda...</i>	<i>mnafanya...</i>
3 they...	<i>manahenda...</i>	<i>βanahenda...</i>	<i>wanafanya...</i>

PRONOUNS IN MIJIKENDA

In Mijikenda, as is general in the northeastern Bantu area, the stem of finite verbs is uninflected for person, so addressing single individuals involves essentially a choice of singular or plural pronoun prefix. Indirect 3rd person address does not occur. The term "pronoun" here covers five main categories: affirmative and negative subject pronoun prefixes, obligatory in the verb phrase; corresponding 2nd-order object pronoun prefixes; independent personal pronouns; and possessive pronouns. Subject pronoun concords vary phonetically between dialects but will be identifiable to those who know Swahili or another Bantu language. In Table 1 examples are given from two Mijikenda varieties, Giriama and Chonyi (with Swahili for reference).

The verb-phrase structure here is:

- (1) Subject + Tense + Verb stem Noun
Ni- + -na- + -henda kazi
 I (present) do work
 'I'm working.'

The independent personal pronouns are nonaffixed forms, used for emphasis or occurring after a preposition or conjunction:

- (2) *Uwe, unahenda kazi* 'You, you're working.'

They are shown in Table 2, compared with the forms of Swahili and Pokomo (spoken to the north).

ADDRESS IN THE NORTHEASTERN BANTU LANGUAGE AREA

Differentiation in the pronouns of address is uncommon in the languages of Eastern Africa, outside the Cushitic group,³ and is absent from most Bantu languages in Kenya, most notably Swahili. Braun, Kohz, and Schubert (1986) listed only a dozen references for Bantu address, only half of which relate

TABLE 2. *Independent pronouns*

Person	Singular			Plural		
	1	2	3	1	2	3
Swahili	<i>mimi</i>	<i>wewe</i>	<i>yeye</i>	<i>sisi</i>	<i>ninyi</i>	<i>wao</i>
Girama	<i>mimi</i>	<i>uwe</i>	<i>iye</i>	<i>siswi</i>	<i>ninwi</i>	<i>ao, aryatu</i>
Kambe	<i>mimi</i>	<i>uwe</i>	<i>iwe</i>	<i>siswi</i>	<i>ninwi</i>	<i>βaβo</i>
Jibana	<i>mimi</i>	<i>uwe</i>	<i>iye</i>	<i>sisi</i>	<i>mwimwi</i>	<i>ao</i>
Ribe/Rabai	<i>mimi</i>	<i>uwe</i>	<i>iye</i>	<i>siswi</i>	<i>mwimwi</i>	<i>ao</i>
Chonyi	<i>mimi</i>	<i>uwe</i>	<i>iye</i>	<i>siswi</i>	<i>mwimwi</i>	<i>βaβo, βaratu</i>
Kauma	<i>mimi</i>	<i>uwe</i>	<i>iye</i>	<i>siswi</i>	<i>ninwi</i>	<i>βaβo, βaratu</i>
Duruma	<i>mimi</i>	<i>uwe</i>	<i>yiye</i>	<i>swiswi</i>	<i>mwimwi</i>	<i>ao</i>
Digo	<i>mimi</i>	<i>uwe</i>	<i>iye</i>	<i>sisi</i>	<i>mwimwi</i>	<i>aho</i>
Pokomo	<i>ami</i>	<i>awe</i>	<i>aje</i>	<i>asu</i>	<i>anyu</i>	<i>ao</i>

to pronominal address forms. Except in the relatively neglected Mijikenda group and in Pokomo, T/V address forms (to use Brown & Gilman's widely understood term for intimate/respectful address) seem to occur unpredictably. To find them so fully developed in this branch of northeastern Bantu raises problems of some relevance for the understanding of the origin and functions of systems of differentiated address generally, as well as unresolved questions about why the system should occur sporadically in some languages but not in others. In the absence of a Mijikenda written tradition, or any oral history extending beyond the 16th century, we are not able to hypothesize (as Brown & Gilman were able to do for Latin) about the origin of such a semantic system. Why it should appear as an isolate in this particular branch of Bantu, but not in adjacent related languages – with kinship and social structures that are otherwise not dissimilar, such as the more stratified Swahili societies – remains unclear.

MIJIKENDA ADDRESS

The rules for address in Mijikenda, summarized in Table 3, are based on kinship but are extended to include affines. Between adult speakers and addressees of adjacent generations – for example, parents and their grown children – a socially required relationship of mutual respect is reflected verbally by the use of reciprocal plurals of address. As an exception, until they reach puberty, *children* in the adjacent generation exchange a singular address form with their parents. Kin or affines of the *same* generation always use reciprocal singular forms, as do alternate generations (grandparents and grandchildren). Relative or absolute age in years plays no part in pronoun selection. An individual's age and generation are independent factors. Re-

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TABLE 3. *Norms of interaction and address*

Generation	Social expression	Linguistic expression	Metalinguistic expression
Adjacent	Respectful behavior	Reciprocal plural	We "respect" each other. She is a "mother".
Same/Alternate	Joking behavior	Reciprocal singular	Bakari "jokes" with me. Don't "respect" me, I'm not your "father" or your "uncle"!

spect has to be expressed to uncles and aunts, though they may be the same age as the speaker or even younger. Similarly, young children are taught to distinguish members of their grandparents' generation (alternate) from the great-grandparents' (nonalternate); they learn that it is permitted to joke with the former, but they must respect the latter. One informant explained: "If I joked with my great-grandmother, my mother would kill me! Who would *she* 'joke' with then?"

From metalinguistic comments such as this (as joking in Mijikenda necessarily involves appropriate address), it is clear that address patterns underline, as well as reinforce, the social norms of respect and dependency between children and their parents' (or great-grandparents') generation, on the one hand, and the alternative values of the nonrespectful joking relationship, on the other. To be sure how to address a person correctly, speakers first need to know their degree of kinship or affinity with the addressee, that is, his or her place within the kinship/affine system. This extralinguistic knowledge is crucial to correct address, because (with a few exceptions discussed later) the covarying pronoun of address can scarcely be avoided, whether in greeting routines, conventional replies, or exchanges generally. Table 4 gives examples of respectful and joking address.

Thus, when a Ribe speaker brought his non-Ribe-speaking American girlfriend home for the weekend, his uncle, on being introduced to the outsider asked:

(3) *Hebu ni muche ama ni mama?* 'Is she a wife or a mother?'

She was neither, as it happened, though in a Mijikenda taxonomy she would have to be classified as one or the other; the same question could equally well have been asked about a distant, little-known Mijikenda relative. Though framed in kin terms, the question's immediate import is metalinguistic: "Should I speak to her respectfully, or casually?" It is a question that carries precisely the same sociosemantic function as French *Je la vouvoie ou je la tutoie?* 'Should I address her as V or T?' Parents and spouses belong to

TABLE 4. *Respectful and joking address*

	Joking form (reciprocal T)	Respect form (reciprocal V)
Morning greeting:	<i>Udzalamkadzde?</i>	<i>Mudzalamkadzde?</i>
Reply (Giriama):	<i>Dzalamuka.</i>	<i>Hudzalamuka.</i>
Evening greeting:	<i>Usindadze?</i>	<i>Musindadze?</i>
Reply (Chonyi):	<i>Nidzisenda.</i>	<i>Hudzisenda.</i>
Farewell (Pokomo):	<i>Nayee!</i>	<i>Nayeeni!</i>

two different generations and are addressed differentially. An addressee who has to be classified socially and treated linguistically as "parent" is one with whom the speaker must maintain a distancing relationship of formality and respect. A "wife," on the other hand, is a member of the same generation; so the singular pronouns used indicate the corresponding relationship of intimacy and informality.

THE IMPORTANCE OF CORRECT ADDRESS

Mijikenda is related to other languages in the area. Pokomo, though only about 60 percent cognate with Mijikenda in core lexis, possesses a similar system of pronouns of respect. Swahili, with 70–75 percent of common vocabulary (indicating a more recent historical separation), seems to have no trace of a comparable T/V usage. This may be an effect of the creolization processes that have resulted in other simplifications, such as a comparatively reduced noun class system, a loss of grammatical/lexical tone, and in acquired non-Bantu phonological and lexical features. Most Mijikenda are bilingual with Swahili (Gorman 1974:355). When code-mixing or code-switching, they frequently introduce Mijikenda L₁ address norms wrongly into Swahili. For example

- (4) (a) *Shangazi, hamjambo?* 'Aunt, how are you (V)?'
 (b) *Hatujambo.* 'We're (i.e., I'm) all right.'

This usage – in place of expected (a) *Shangazi, hujambo?* (b) *Sijambo* – reflects an L₁ interference that would not occur in the speech of native Swahili speakers, or of L₂ speakers of Swahili from other ethnic areas of Kenya or Tanzania. The overriding importance of expressing proper respect (whatever the language actually being used) gives rise to frequent instances of such loan interferences. A Giriama speaker mentioned his nephew's use of plural address when *writing* to him in Swahili, something a native speaker of Swahili would never do. Another nephew, writing in English, revealed their underlying V relationship by use of the plural in self-reference ("We are O.K."), a form generally associated in English with heads of state: for example, Mrs. Thatcher's "We are a grandmother." It is unclear whether the use of the 1st person plural in unequal (respectful) dyadic exchanges is always required and sustained for the duration of the exchange or produced as a reflex in response to a plural of address; the instances recorded occurred mainly in greeting routines but were not limited to the older member of the dyad. The same Giriama speaker, a lecturer in Swahili, related that his nieces aged 10–12 years, when visiting his family, address him (correctly) in the plural in Giriama. But his own children, who speak only Swahili at home (and know but do not use Giriama), find their cousins' use of the plural strange, "as if he is many."

AUTHORITY AND RESPECT IN MIJIKENDA SOCIETIES

Traditional Mijikenda society has been frequently described as a "gerontocracy" (Berg-Schlosser 1984; Brantley 1978; Parkin 1972), in which male seniority confers inalienable authority. The locus of this authority is to be found within the family, in the primary biological and social relationship of father-child: an intrinsically unequal dependency relationship, which is maintained at the individual and social levels by normative requirements among which respectful behavior is paramount. In Mijikenda society, the biological, the social, and the linguistic dimensions of the social order overlap in near total congruence, insofar as kin, social respect, and address are mutually reinforcing systems. Every act of address unavoidably situates all members of the society in their respective kin and generational position and reminds them of their consequent status.

Respect for the father as *mwenye mudzi* 'head of household' is the prime obligation for ensuring social stability. The head of household is a domestic patriarch in every sense: a *paterfamilias*, combining the traditional multiplicity of roles (political, juridical, economic, and ritual) found in other relatively undifferentiated small-scale societies. He is indisputably the topman, the owner and guardian of the family property, the giver and receiver of wealth. It is he who provides bridewealth for his grown sons, so that they can marry; hence their dependency on him is consequently considerable, until they marry and eventually leave to set up their own homesteads. A relationship of enjoined mutual respect is an obvious way to ensure social order, cooperation, and domestic harmony.

The father also receives bridewealth for his daughters; he has to manage this income competently, like other family resources. As head of household he receives and redistributes other cash income from the sale of crops, palms, wine, and so forth, and he acts as spokesman concerning the ownership, use, or transfer of property. In the absence of a system of title registration, an elder in this patriarchal, preliterate society has a powerful role to play as witness or arbitrator of the ownership of land and of entitlement to economically important property such as palms or other trees. Local policy-making rests with him and his peers as householders and elders, in *barazas* 'public meetings', or other councils of elders convened to discuss infringements of customary law.

The *mwenye mudzi* has further important ritual responsibilities in the organization of funerals and other major ceremonies, such as marriages, divinations, and ordeals. He may be a traditional healer and rainmaker. In the juridical area, he has the power to impose fines for misdemeanors relating to various areas of social conduct. The father/elder, in short, is at the apex of a local micro-society in which he enjoys the powers and authority of magistrate, manager, religious counselor, diviner, and traditional

doctor. His decision making extends over the whole household (which in former days could number 40–60 individuals), but it directly and most importantly affects his offspring, who, in this polygamous society, can be numerous.

Social order, cooperation, and harmony require the members of each generation to behave with respect toward their parents. The nurturance of children imposes a debt on them that they will eventually have to repay by supporting their parents in old age, and so it will be for each successive generation. Respect for parents, especially the father, is the cardinal value. The reciprocal showing of respect by fathers toward their adolescent children can in turn be seen as a way of establishing a regulatory social distance, of mitigating the children's essentially subservient and unequal dependency – and, one hopes, of reducing friction, within the large extended household.

Address in Mijikenda functions as a linguistic reflex of these primary patterns of kinship and affinity, constantly reminding speakers of them. By classificatory extensions, everyone in the community is a known kin, affine, or both; hence, extensions of the forms of address are predetermined and normally quite predictable, unlike T/V usage in European languages.

In a traditional Mijikenda family, still largely unaffected by Westernization, great stress is laid on “respect” as a proper form of behavior and a set of attitudes, to be learned as part of the process of growing up. Berg-Schlosser (1984:93) noted that Mijikenda fathers help foster an early and proper hierarchical sense of respect by the use of fairly severe physical chastisement, an observation confirmed by several consultants.

LEARNING THE LINGUISTIC ROPES

Infants and young children are addressed in the singular and are allowed to speak in the singular to their parents (or to relatives of the parents' generation), usually until the age of 8–9 years. They will go on using the singular with siblings, cousins, and grandparents throughout their life. But from the age of about 9, children and parents start to “respect” one another and change to plural address forms. (One Mijikenda speaker recalled switching at age 11, and his brother at age 14; in Pokomo the use of V may start as late as 18.) Parents' brothers and sisters – that is, the child's uncles and aunts, who may be members of the same extended household – will also expect to be addressed with a plural of respect from this age.

This plural is reciprocal: All address forms, whether T or V, are normally reciprocated. Usage is often underpinned by naming conventions and by respectful titles; thus a first son will be given the same name as his paternal grandfather, and so can be addressed semijocularly as *baba* ‘father’ + V by his own father. One speaker, a younger son named in strict convention af-

ter another relative, recounted that his parents addressed him as *mutumia* 'old man' + V, as they would any elder of their own parents' generation.

After the switch, children also should demand to be respected, that is, to receive respectful plural address forms not just from parents but also from their own nephews and nieces, even if they are older. The extending and requiring of *heshimu* 'respect' on the part of the child approaching puberty is encouraged and applauded. It will be taught both by parents and grandparents (especially the grandmother, who plays an important role in the child's education). Children will be taught to respect their parents largely by grandparents who, of course, also respect those same parents – their adult offspring, linguistically. This extending and receiving of respect can nowadays give rise to situations where traditional norms run up against modern Western values. A well-educated Giriama speaker, holding down a high-status job in the modern sector, spoke of his initial resentment at having to respect his father's newly acquired traditional second wife with *Mama* + V because she was 15 years younger than him, illiterate, and had nothing like his status. He had tried addressing her in the singular, only to be reproved by his own mother and other mothers, because his usage was "disrespectful to his father."

Several male speakers report that a reciprocal singular form of address may continue to be used between a boy and his mother (though not with her co-wives) after puberty, particularly if there is an especially close personal relationship. But this intimate singular is avoided in the father's presence, again as a sign of respect – a type of politeness identified by Comrie (1976) as "bystander honorifics" and not dissimilar to the kinds of large-scale code-switching that occur in Australian languages (see Dixon 1980), where kinship and other social distinctions are also encoded by means of pronoun systems.

Respect will normally also include restrictions on certain topics (such as sexuality, subject to taboos between adjacent generations), styles (i.e., informality more appropriate to a joking relationship), and speech acts (such as direct commands to an older adjacent-generation addressee). Although code-switching is commonplace, the use of Swahili in direct address to a father or father's brother was considered disrespectful by one speaker, perhaps because respect cannot be expressed pronominally in that language. Bawdy or obscene language (*kufiola*), quite permissible with one's grandmother, would never be tolerated in conversation with one's father or mother. A Ribe speaker put it graphically: *Undariwa makosa* 'You will be eaten by (i.e., have to pay) a fine.'

These repressions are largely suspended, however, during the carnival-like atmosphere accompanying funerals. These are occasions when much palm wine is consumed, a general air of bacchanalia occurs, and "everything breaks down." During the 3–6 days of the funeral, sexual as well as linguistic statuses are frequently abandoned or renegotiated, and the singular is used

for everyone except one's own mother and father. New forms of address become possible, for example, (Giriama) *Tsangazimi, ndzooni!* 'Auntie, come here!' – an odd collocation of respectful kin term, respectful plural, and unexpected imperative. The whole utterance amounts to a disrespectful joke, for even if couched in the plural, an imperative of this kind conflicts with what is normally permissible in speech act terms.

The linguistic respect first shown to parents will be extended later in life to affines, especially to mother- and father-in-law, as well as to their kin and affines. The function of respect, as a distancing modality for creating and maintaining good relations and mutual obligations among all the adult members of the society, becomes very apparent. Respecting provides the means for avoiding face-threatening behavior, for handling difficult or taboo relationships, and for avoiding tensions or conflict within the large, multi-generational extended family of the Mijikenda household.

The intergenerational norms of address that all Mijikenda learn are summarized as follows:

- Rule 1. Adjacent generations exchange *plural* respect forms (reciprocal V).
- Rule 2. All kin and affines of parents' generation (i.e., those with whom parents are familiar) receive the *plural* respect forms extended to parents (reciprocal V).
- Rule 3. Alternate generations exchange *singular* "joking" forms (reciprocal T).
- Rule 4. All members of speaker's generation exchange *singular* "joking" forms (reciprocal T).

CREATIVE VARIATION IN ADDRESS FORMS

Whereas the foregoing patterns normally determine the majority of everyday interactions, there are inevitably less clear-cut occasions when uncertainties over address arise. There is also some scope for creative variation and exploitation within the system. Such variation is cited by speakers as arising typically out of uncertainty regarding the kin identity of strangers – or, alternatively, from situations where the social requirement for respect between adjacent generations conflicts with an individual's desire for an intimate interpersonal relationship.

In traditional Mijikenda society, not only is everyone *known* to one another; at the local level, whether through kinship or marriage, all members of the community are also somehow *related*. All individuals can therefore be located in a social-generational matrix. "Unknown" persons – those who cannot be located within the kin/affine/generation matrices – are normally given a plural address form, until some appropriate group membership is established. In other circumstances, where considerable difference in age or addressee's sex is pertinent, respectful titles such as *tsawe* 'grandfather', *mutumia*

'elder', or *tsangazi* 'aunt' might do. To treat addressees respectfully where this is inappropriate is still a gaffe, though a lesser one than to treat them jokingly. Problems and uncertainty can arise in the not infrequent cases of double kin relationships. One speaker cited the case of a woman who was his aunt on his father's side, and whom he therefore addressed in the respectful plural in his father's presence. As the same woman was also his cousin (through his mother), he was expected to address her in the informal singular if only his mother were present. If both parents were present, the aunt/cousin would receive respectful V – in overt deference not to her, but to the head of the household.

The taxonomic nature of address is revealed by another type of situation. A man's cousin is a classificatory sibling, whom he would normally address in the joking singular; if that man marries his daughter, and so becomes his son-in-law (who should be addressed in the plural), then reciprocal plural address becomes possible. The form of address adopted in practice would depend on a number of factors, contextual as well as interpersonal. If the previous relationship had not been especially close or friendly, or if the age difference between speaker and son-in-law/cousin was considerable, then the plural might be used. The presence of certain other kin would also determine choice.

One can sometimes exploit the system's ambiguities creatively. A Ribe speaker related that his father had hired a young Chonyi man who addressed his employer in the plural. This respect naturally required the employer to be mutually respectful and located the Chonyi employee in a particular way vis-à-vis his employer: in effect, as a son. The decision had nothing to do with relative age, or with status as employee or outsider. But, as an outsider, the Chonyi was nevertheless free to use a *different* form of address, the joking singular, with his employer's younger brothers, and more especially his younger sisters. As he was an outsider to the kin system, this was not considered a breach of customary etiquette; and as he was now on joking terms with them, he could freely use his powers of seduction on the young women in question.

A hypothetical example of creative switching was suggested by another speaker. If he was attracted to a young woman who was technically his aunt (a taboo relationship), then he might try using the singular in private; if she reciprocated, he could feel optimistic about his chances. Because they were nephew and aunt, both parties would still be expected to maintain the plural in public; an inadvertent slip to a singular might do more than set tongues wagging. But if his advances (signaled linguistically) were unwelcome, or too persistent, then this could constitute a form of *makosa* 'social misdemeanor'. Reported to the elders, it could result in his having to pay a fine: some palm wine, a chicken, or possibly even a goat (in the case of a persistent offender).

The failure to pay due respect is purely verbal, effected simply by the choice of address form T. The semantic implications of such rule-breaking, however, take the transgression out of the realm of the merely verbal into the arena of social misconduct; it strikes at the very concept of proper respect, authority, and, ultimately, at the roots of social order. The fine underlines the socially disruptive nature of the offense.

In recent years, growth of trading centers and increased mobility has started bringing together Mijikenda speakers who are unknown to each other and are from different subgroups (e.g., Giriama and Chonyi). Parkin (1980:54) mentioned a new strategy devised for getting around uncertainty about proper address forms (at least in the initial greeting routines); this is the recent emergence of "highly shortened, semi-jocular greetings, devoid of pronominal and tense affixes . . . [that have] developed between young men and women in place of greetings whose elaborate forms were structured by and in turn reinforced generation, kinship, and sex differences." But in practice it is difficult to imagine how the subsequent badinage between the urban young could proceed without pronominal affixes; this would run counter to the fundamental syntax of a language that has not so far needed pidginized, simplified or, "foreigner" varieties. Indeed, the emergence of zero forms, like the use of unidiomatic Swahili plurals, indirectly attests once again to the underlying importance for Mijikenda speakers of selecting the socially correct pronoun.

Another kind of short-term switching occurred between a husband and wife, who normally used reciprocal singular. On public ceremonial occasions, such as dances or funeral gatherings, their switch from T to V was interpreted as a mark of mutual respect. However, another couple made a similar switch when there was tension between them. In this instance, switching to the plural was interpreted as a way of defusing the situation and retreating from face-threatening conflict. As Braun (1988:46) pointed out, even within a single culture T/V forms may be laden with ambiguous values; what is polite or appropriate is not a constant but is subject to contextual redefinition. Another switch to a linguistically *marked* form (i.e., unusual in this particular social context) was the opposite of the previous one: An adult speaker's mother, who addressed him correctly in the plural in one-to-one exchanges (respected him), switched to the singular when other women were present, to show her pride and affection. A final example of short-term switching was the exact opposite: A father was having a row with his young son, with whom he had just begun to be on mutually respectful terms. But respect and conflict are incompatible, or ought to be; so the father reverted to the intimate singular, in order to sound off at his son more effectively. This recalls the switch from V to T frequently made in European languages in situations of conflict (e.g., threat or abuse).

JOKING AND INTIMACY

Some reference has already been made to the converse of respect, that particular kind of African informality/intimacy called *utani* in Mijikenda and that translates somewhat unsatisfactorily in English as the 'joking relationship'. The nature of this relationship, like the form taken by respect and deference in different societies, varies widely.⁴ Radcliffe-Brown and Forde (1950:30) described the forms it can take in Bantu systems of kinship and marriage, though without mentioning any linguistic reflex:

Between two proximate generations, the relation is normally one of essential inequality, authority, and protective care on the one side, respect and dependence on the other. But between the generations of grand-parents and grand-children, the relation is a contrasting one of friendly familiarity and near equality . . . , privileged familiarity . . . and permitted disrespect.

People who joke are not only permitted, but *expected*, to speak and behave to each other in ways that would be insulting and offensive in people not so related.

In many ways, the patterns of intergenerational respect in Mijikenda areas differ little from those found elsewhere in Africa. What distinguishes Mijikenda is that joking and respect relationships are overlaid with a linguistic correlate, in the systems of pronominal address; this is quite absent elsewhere. The very first pronoun of address used in an encounter, in this society, reveals which of the two vastly dissimilar relationships pertains between two speakers, before any other attitudinal or behavioral differences are noted.

METALINGUISTIC REFERENCE TO RESPECT

As joking and respect are overtly marked in speech, the Mijikenda verbs *kutania* 'to joke with' and *kuheshimu* 'to respect' have both referential and metalinguistic meaning. Although they are not derived delocutives like French *tutoyer*, German *duzen*, and so forth, they seem in many contexts to refer only to the *linguistic* level of the expression of respect or its converse, rather than to nonverbal behavior (though in practice it is often impossible to separate the two). Similarly, lexical kinship terms also invoke or imply a metalinguistic level of reference, because every kinship term collocates either with T or with V.

In a small-scale rural society – one that is unstratified and stable and in which everyone knows everyone else – address is hardly ever a problem at the homestead level. An individual walking along a path will always know how to address someone encountered along the way, whether in the respectful

plural or in the intimate singular. Where problems can arise is in classifying newcomers to the neighborhood, or when ceremonial occasions (especially funerals, the major social event in Mijikenda life) bring less familiar relatives to the homestead. On such occasions, if two people do not know how they are related, then they do not know initially how to address each other correctly (see ex. 16). To do so, they must first discover their actual degree of kinship or affinity.

Because the concept of due and appropriate levels of respect is central to Mijikenda social life, it is not surprising that reference is often made to the linguistic correlate of respectful or joking nonverbal behavior, as every act of address to a single listener underscores that relationship. The most common verb meaning 'to respect' is the Swahili loanword *kuheshimu*, with its derivatives: reciprocal *kuheshimiana* 'respect one another', passive *kuheshimiwa* 'be respected', and so on. This Swahili-Arabic stem has generally replaced Bantu equivalents in Mijikenda, though some Bantu homonyms are retained, for example, Pokomo *kuhilana* 'to respect', Giriama *kuogoha* 'to fear/respect'. Examples 5-7 all make metalinguistic reference to pronoun of address.

- (5) *Kuniheshimu?* (Chonyi)
'Why don't you respect me?' (i.e., use the polite V form).
- (6) *Hunaheshimiana.* (Chonyi)
'We respect each other' (address each other as V).
- (7) *Kahuheshimiana.* (Chonyi)
'We don't respect each other' (we use familiar T).

The negative of the verb 'to respect' paraphrases the meaning 'to joke', reflecting the binarity of the joking/respect relationships, and can be used metalinguistically.

- (8) *Kahuheshimiana.* = *Hunatseana.*
'We don't respect each other' = 'We joke with each other'
(i.e., we address each other in the singular).

The negative of 'to joke' is similarly used.

- (9) *Kahutseana.* = *Hunaheshimiana.*
'We don't joke with each other' = 'We respect each other'
(i.e., we address each other using V).

A greater variety of verbs exists to express the alternative joking relationship and its pronominal usage, for example, Chonyi and Giriama *kutsea*, Duruma *kubishira*, Pokomo *kuk'osa*, Ribe *kufiola* 'to joke obscenely'. Swahili *kutania* is also known and used as a loanword, though perhaps less frequently.

- (10) *Usinitsee!* (Chonyi)
'Don't joke with me!' (i.e., don't address me familiarly).
- (11) *Bakari yunanitsea.* (Chonyi)
'Bakari jokes with me' (i.e., Bakari addresses me in the singular).

- (12) *Yudzinitsea!* (Chonyi)

'He has been disrespectful to me!'

In an immediately metalinguistic reference of this kind, the verb 'to respect' or 'to joke' is often reinforced by invoking the kin relationship and corresponding term.

- (13) *Usinitanie, si tsaweyo mino, ni babayo!* (Ribe)

'Don't joke with *me*, I'm not your grandfather, I'm your father!' (i.e., don't treat *me* with undue familiarity, I'm not [like your] grandfather, I'm [like your] father!).

- (14) *Usiniheshimu, ni ndguyo.* (Ribe)

'Don't respect me, I'm a brother' (i.e., no need to be formal, I'm of your generation).

- (15) [Speaker is informant's "grandfather"]

Usiniheshimu, si babayo ama babayo muhoho! (Ribe)

'Don't respect me, I'm not your father or your uncle.'

The verb *kumanya* 'to know, be acquainted' (with someone) can also be used to express the metalinguistic notion.

- (16) *Kahumanyana.* (Chonyi)

'We don't know each other' (i.e., we don't know what kin relatedness we have, and hence how to address each other correctly).

When two individuals do know each other, they are generally quite clear about how their language should reflect this knowledge, and not only in the form of address they choose. A Giriama speaker explained: "You respect your great-grandfather because he is like your father"; that is, he has to be addressed with respect like your father, because they respect one another.

Another Giriama speaker reported that a woman friend of his mother's (by implication, someone of her generation) had complained to his mother about the speaker's lack of respect in addressing her.

- (17) *Mbona, yuno mwanao ananitsea?* (Giriama)

'Why is your son joking with me?' (i.e., not respecting me).

The rebuke is less oblique in Mijikenda, where everyone knows that a son should not joke with a mother.

Reproaches about lack of respect (ex. 5, 10, and 13) are couched in the singular. Respect is mutual, and when one party has infringed the rules of politeness, the respect form is not extended to that person.

How to address outsiders to the homestead world can be a real problem, as shown by the experience of the Ribe speaker who brought his American girlfriend home. At a loss to know how to address her appropriately, because she could clearly not be located in the kinship structure with which he was familiar, the speaker's uncle asked: *Hebu ni muche ama ni mama?* 'Is she a wife or a mother?' This revealed an immediate dilemma, whether to use singular or plural to greet and address the woman; but it implicitly asked what behavior should be adopted – joking and intimate, or respectful and distant.

PRONOUNS OF POWER AND SOLIDARITY

Brown and Gilman's "two emperors" hypothesis (1960:255) has had a remarkably long and successful run, despite the weakness of its particularistic explanation for what turns out to be a rather general phenomenon. It does not seem to be an explanation we can use to account for a system of differentiated address in Mijikenda or in other non-European languages. Recognizing its weakness, Brown (1965:51) pointed toward a more general explanation: "The likelihood that *metaphor* directed the usage is increased by the fact that languages unrelated to Latin have independently developed the plural of respect." However, the emphasis on power and solidarity in the earlier article is carried through, and asymmetrical plural address (a marked form) is still largely seen as a metaphor for power.

Brown and Levinson (1987:198) also argued that "particular cultural explanations will not do in the face of this widespread distribution [of pluralized *you* and *I* pronouns], the extent of which has not been appreciated." They offered two alternative theories: (1) Plural address is a kind of non-face-threatening "conventional indirectness," because the addressee is not singled out. (2) In kinship-based societies, "to treat persons as representatives of a group rather than as relatively powerless individuals would be to refer to their social standing."

In Mijikenda, however, although kinship terms always imply group status and membership, they do not of themselves entail the plural. Certain kin terms co-occur with a respectful plural, others co-occur only with the singular (see ex. 13-15). Plurality cannot therefore be seen merely as a metaphor for group membership, the person addressed being "one of many." Nor, equally, is it merely a unidirectional metaphor for power. This begs the question of its reciprocity. This is a society where actual power is very unevenly distributed, but nevertheless it is one where everyone is respected (by adjacent generations) and joked with (by own and alternate generations); where even an illiterate teenage second wife must be shown respect by a successful "modern" stepson twice her age; a society in which the generations interlock in two fundamental relationships according to kinship and affinity.

Yet if respect and joking are symmetric, power is most decidedly asymmetric. Real power has a domestic locus: that of the position of the Mijikenda *mwenye mudzi*, an East African domestic patriarch equivalent in almost all respects to the Roman *paterfamilias* or *dominus* 'master, lord' of the household (from *domus* 'house').

Even if we reject Brown and Gilman's explanation for the origin and diffusion of plurals of respect, we can nevertheless see semantic parallels in Latin for many of the terms that relate to social power structures found in the Mijikenda domain and that involve a patriarchal domestic geron-

tocracy based on unequal power. Apart from *dominus*, they include terms such as *magister* ‘master’ (from *magis* ‘more [powerful]’); *senex* ‘elder’, whose comparative *senior* has produced many of the terms in European languages for respectful address to patriarchal power figures (Eng. *sir*; Fr. *seigneur*, *sire*, *monsieur*, etc.); and *Senatus populusque romanus* ‘the Roman Council-of-Elders [Senate] and People’.

The extended Roman household with its domestic patriarch and elder, many of whose duties were similar to those of the Mijikenda *mwenye mudzi*, would seem to provide at least as immediate and obvious a source from which to derive respect forms as the imperial palace. The titles used in respectful direct address (*dominus*, *domina*), though later extended to the Emperor, are clearly domestic in origin. It seems much more probable that the plural of respect *vos* would be a marked pronoun reflex of the respect terms used by the powerless in the family (*familia*, from *famulus* ‘slave’, collectively referred to the house slaves) to address the master (*magister*) and mistress of the household, and that it would be transferred in everyday speech to any authority figure, along with the corresponding term *dominus*. It also seems likely that T/V pronominal use in, say, the Germanic languages, may have had more to do with similar (and preexisting) structures of power and respect within the Germanic (or Indo-European) household, rather than with a slavish propensity to borrow late Latin address forms.

Linguistic innovation, on the whole, is likely to take place and find fertile ground where the social and semantic structures are favorable to it. The “stimulus diffusion” of plural pronouns of respect in this view, then, is likely to have been a bottom-up rather than a top-down innovation: an extension to the head of society of that collocation of title and pronoun that was used in address-form deference to the domestic patriarch within the family. The later restriction of *dominus* to authority figures beyond the family is paralleled by the semantic shift of its English equivalent *lord* (from Anglo-Saxon *hlaf-ward* ‘loaf-keeper’).

Given the widespread distribution and social adaptation of systems of address worldwide, the address forms found in Mijikenda suggest they function as a carrier of several overlapping meanings in that society. Plural address actualizes the respect all individuals should show their father, the absolute ruler in the household – and also his generation, in witness of their power and authority (as a group) to decide, to command, to punish. This patriarchal power is inalienable within Mijikenda society, and the respect it engenders is shared even by the powerless affines of the father’s generation. But respect (unlike power) is not personally inalienable; it is a function of one’s relative position in a kin network, or in a dyad vis-à-vis an addressee. In Mijikenda even the powerful must not be respected by members of their own generation (brothers, sisters, wives), nor by their grandmothers or grandchildren!

Plural address, used by parents to their children approaching nine, carries a message of a different type (just as the T pronouns of European languages can ambiguously signal intimacy and friendship, or aggression and abuse). Respect shown to a younger adjacent generation cannot be a recognition of the deference owed to power, because the young are powerless and dependent. Rather, it recognizes that children approaching adolescence are becoming social persons in their own right and that boys are the genetic inheritors of the patriarchal lineage in this polygamous society, as well as being the future elders of the group. Naming conventions remind all and sundry that the first-born son of each wife "will be a 'father'," that is, be the *somo* 'name-sake' of father's father, and that the other children, too, are the previous generation reborn, an assurance of the continuity of the social group. Having children in itself confers respected status: Swahili *baba (wa) watoto* 'father of children' is a homegrown honorific, not a loan translation of *pater-familias*! Extension to children of the expression of respect given to parents serves at once to distance them as well as to accord them status, recognizes them socially as members of a rising generation. As Goffman (1967:44-45) reminded us,

societies everywhere, if they are to be societies, must mobilize their members as self-regulating participants in social encounters . . . The general capacity to be bound by moral rules may well belong to the individual, but the particular set of rules which transforms him into a human being derives from requirements established in the ritual organization of social encounters.

CONCLUSION

This article examines address forms in Mijikenda and their role in marking explicitly the position of individuals within a network of kin relationships basic to Mijikenda society. The social, ritual, and economic roles of importance concentrated in the head of household constitute the basic asymmetry of power between parent and child, which filial respect recognizes. Parental respect for the rising adjacent generation – those between whom mutual reliance and conflict are greatest – is effected by the use of reciprocal plural pronouns of address, in addition to other norms of polite behavior. Kin and affines of the same generation share a joking relationship of intimacy and solidarity, explicit in their use of a singular form of address. Grandparents and grandchildren enjoy the same relationship, devoid of deference and distance. With few exceptions, and in a manner quite unlike that in which European languages order such relationships, respect is determined dyadically by kinship and affinity, not by a socially or individually arrived-at assessment of intimacy and distance dependent on solidary or nonsolidary

criteria, or by assessment of the addressee's social status, class, age, sex, or profession. Everyone at times respects and is respected, jokes and is joked with. In order to address an unknown woman correctly in Mijikenda, you must know whether she is of your own, your mother's, or your grandmother's generation. You need to know, as the Mijikenda put it, "Is she a wife or a mother?"

The unequal distribution of power between parents and children, young and old, heads of households and dependents, is fairly universal. It seems likely that the examination of languages other than Mijikenda will further confirm that address forms are a primary linguistic means of marking and reinforcing these social structures and norms in the arena where their relevance is most immediate, that is, at the everyday domestic and microsocial, rather than the public and formal levels; and that plural address, as a marked form, is a widespread (if sometimes ambiguous) linguistic metaphor for deference and respect.

NOTES

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2. The Mijikenda dialect cluster is located mainly in Coast Province (Kwale and Kilifi Districts), Kenya. Speakers of the two most southern dialects, Duruma and Digo, are also found on the northern Tanzanian coast.
3. For a description of pronouns of respect in Amhara (Ethiopia), see Hoben (1976); for Tigrinya, see Braun (1984).
4. Rigby (1968) gave a detailed analysis of the enormous behavioral complexity of the joking relationship in a Bantu language of Tanzania.

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